POETRY PORTFOLIO

SPRING 2026 PIECES AND EXERCISES

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Artist's Process

Nothing enrages me more than the notion of the idea "coming to" or being "found by" the artist. An idea is anything I decide *is an idea. There's ideas in your current surroundings. There's ideas in my breakfast. There's ideas in every conversation, every sensation, every occupation. The world is littered with them, and my job is simply to decide one of them gets to truly live, drop its seed into the offensive soil of a blank page, and listen as it whispers to me how it is meant to grow.*

When it has spread everywhere it could ever be across every corner of the space, I must overpower it, don scalpel and brass knuckles, and lovingly pummel it in the gut until it spills bottled emotion across the page and begs for mercy. I take a chisel and don't stop carving until I see aching, shimmering bone. When I've finished and the tortured, anguished thing in front of me screams in tune with my inner monologue, I lock it away in a drawer until I forget it ever existed. I either find it as a finished piece or catch a hint of free will and look for the woodchipper.

Poetry Section

neon graveyard

is it enough to sit and count
the years that pass as i sketch
each bone in the neon graveyard?

the metal monsters start to stretch,
the scales aglow, the eyes aware
of the years that pass as i sketch.

my history stops to catch my stare;
it knows my shame, my ignorance
of the scales aglow, and eyes aware.

a horseshoe's radiant decadence
unfolds a fractal 8 million miles,
and knows my shame, my ignorance.

i'll never forget the smiles
of each bone in the neon graveyard,
fractals unfolding for millions of miles!

why can't i sing the elegy
of each bone in the neon graveyard?
is it enough to sit and count
each bone in the neon graveyard?

Orange sunset

i walk a Desert road, alone.
alone with my thoughts, i pause.
i pause to ponder its Bend.

the moment widens, Orange.
Orange before me, around me.
around me like the first hug of Summer.

Orange is Firsts, electric.
electric brush of an arm, the first.
the first glow of a child’s eyes.

Orange freezes, darkens.
darkens all things real before.
before shadowy strokes and melting Sherbert.

Orange is Courage, untainted.
untainted novelty, young and Free.
Free from inconveniences of real and of rational.

i sit in Orange, holding.
holding a pen, or brush to slice Yearning.
to slice Yearning out of its bosom.

Orange opens, Sisyphean.
Sisyphean in worship of before.
before the Bend in the road.

Orange traps me in a Dream.
Dream catcher of memories, forgotten.
forgotten by the shadows moored in time.

Orange won’t allow me.
allow me back to the stretch before.
before eternity shatters.

i turn the bend. the Sun sets. Nothing.
nothing frolic or fortunate left.
left to share a Sophism of finality.

how to survive the apocalypse

when the apocalypse comes,
you need to buy a gun.
you need to buy a knife, a big one.
you need to buy zombie repellant,
and a good book, and love.

some of these you won’t even use,
but you can buy them,
and you need to.

when the apocalypse comes,
you need to buy a car to get around.
to get away from whatever has come.
you need to buy razor spikes
to line the sides, as many as you can.

you need to buy gas, and
you need to buy a warranty just in case.
you don’t know what the apocalypse will break,
so you need to insure it all.

when the apocalypse comes,
you need to buy water,
a can opener, socks
to keep your roots in, a radio

to talk to your loneliness, and a flashlight
to scare it off.

you don’t like the loneliness,
but any kind of hole can be filled
if you buy the right shape of peg.

when the apocalypse comes,
you need to buy comfort.
you need to buy a blanket, and a tent, and matches.
you need to buy a passport as a reminder
that you aren’t one of “them” whoever “they” may be.
you need to buy freedom, and you need to buy pads
because even the apocalypse hates women.

you need to buy shoes with strong souls,
and a fortress, and a laugh,
and everything anyone ever brought
to an abandoned island.

you need to buy any other survivors out
of the game, tell yourself that’s all it is,
and buy everything when no one else is left.

moon poem

sometimes… i hug my blanket close,

and pretend it's you.

and when i turn around, i feel

its thermal mass like a ghost on my back,

and i pretend it’s you.

i feel the ink river along

my upper arm lapping against the cliffs

beneath yours as the sun gives way

to you, and it feels right,

and i pretend it's my moon.

i cry.

and i sleep well.

how to disappear

i am called Missile. fear me, child,
for i have come. i will not miss;
i am named not for aim but for Purpose.
my title means "Sent"
ancient, Romantic, elusive of blame.

They watch you, through my blinking, metal Eyes,
though you'll see nothing, hear nothing
as i poke my steel-beaked face
through the fog of your night,
by Nacht und Nebel.

i'm natural, you see,
like the great earth contorting her back
to dislodge some evil pest.
They call me Patriot, cunning, Watchful,
flung from David's Sling.

when you fall, goliath,
into the severed arms of your loving mother,
know that i will have died to your evil,
split myself apart to engulf you in my Warmth
and mist you with my blood like Holy water.
would you rather they Send people?

you are my sacred Mission,
my beloved guiding hand.
don't worry now, the Game is ending soon.
i will land. we will die.
and Everyone will be safe.

say cheese.

Writing Exercises

Show Not Tell

Write a few lines (minimum 3, maximum 7) for each example.

Physical sensation: *It's raining. How does the rain feel, smell, as you step out the door.*

Figurative language: *You are holding your guitar… how?*

By divine right, it smacks straight into the top of my head.

A drop of water, and another, and a third on my nose.

As they fall, faster, I feel them saturate my clothes.

I tuck my shoulders towards the ground, but not far enough.

My vesicant-soaked garment is everywhere, inescapable.

A fourth drop hits my hand, and I am nothing.

#

My feet sway as they dangle off the edge, reaching towards white nothing below.

I hug my only friend tight in my lap before pinching the second string and strumming a solitary note.

It sounds the same in the clouds.

I feel the strap slide up and down my back as I turn, keeping the old guitar tethered to me.

It won't fall without me, nor, it being in front of me, me without it.

I let go, and it pulls away from my chest slightly, tightening the strap and nudging me towards the brink.

I fall if it falls, and, it being strapped to my back, it falls if I do.

Origami

Write your own poem that folds, creases, and shapes. You know… Write a poem that has echoes.

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really real sure

> *Semantic satiation is a [...] phenomenon in which repetition causes a word or phrase to temporarily lose meaning*" – Wikipedia

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    are you real?
i'm not–
    aha!
–real–
    you're caught!
–ly sure.
    surely not?
surely not sure, for sure!
    not so sure or not so real?
not sure that i'm so real.
    no you're not!
yes. i'm not.
    you are. you are!
i'm not, really.
    you're not, or you're not really?
i'm not.
    really?
really.
    "i'm not … really." or "really? really."? or really real or
really sure?
dude. really?
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Image Writing

Naomi Shihab Nye says when we are not writing, we're gathering. Perhaps like squirrels gathering nuts for winter. Or maybe it's like laying in wood for fires: dragging logs to the clearing, cutting and stacking. It's good work, exercises the muscles and gets the blood flowing. In these times, sentences, phrases, the act of describing, gets the blood going, the mind working. So take a walk with your journal and gather images. Write at least five of them in your journal. Upload two.

There's something with you in the dark. It isn't quite a person but the whisper of one, bent to lean against the nail of the acrylic middle finger sprawled across the wall behind the gas station, inflating as the light at the end of a cigarette slides smoothly down its length in one breath.

#

With the windows down, it's hard not to stare out as life is thrown past or smell the petrichor on the city's breath or hear the engine grumbling as it grows angrier and feel its engineered appetite reverberating through you.

Extended Metaphor

how to buy Love

loneliness grows on trees
like a pit grows in a peach
and only your Wallet can Save you.

plant Chocolate behind teeth
and watch the ground Love sprout
like a Pit grows in a peach.

Love can't come soon enough,
so Buy it all year round
and watch the ground sprout Love.

Love costs Flowers, must be allowed
to watch beauty Wilt and die,
so Buy them all year round.

Burn Love like the wick of a Candle
poke it until it makes Spectacle,
then watch beauty Wilt and die.

Hunt Love in the air at a Festival,
Tie it down with ribbons and bows,
and poke it until it makes Spectacle,

Buy it away from its homes in poem and prose
because Love is an Expensive Spell,
Tied down with ribbons and bows.

draw st. valentine’s Love from secret marriages
into Spectacular Panopticons of Stuff
because Love is an Expensive Spell.

the Warning grows as a seed in you
like a Pit growing in a peach
that loneliness grows on trees,
and only your Wallet can Save you.

Time as a Bubble

Imagine a bubble. Picture it around you, and then imagine it expanding to the space next to you. It grows to the next room, then your house, then the neighborhood. Keep writing.

Time is a machine.

I imagined I had stopped it once. I asked it what it did for me, as I stroked its glass surfaces, fueling it with my engrossment. When it refused to speak, I didn't smash it in anger, but turned it off and left it to yearn for my touch. It stopped.

First, it stopped my heart pounding bleak eternities into my chest. It stopped the spread of death beneath my eyes and the bleeding of my breath. Next, it stopped my mother knitting in the other room. She cocked her head as she exited her trance and put the half-gift away to start again outside of time.

It stopped my neighbors circulating like RC ants on one quest or another. They grouped in their homes, and they hugged, and felt nothing but the comfort of love. It stopped the cars, leaving us with long walks through the breezy grass. I smiled at a man and a man outside of time, holding coffee cups and each other's hands.

It stopped the world ending every second of every day. It started people living, in a bubble outside a machine.

Pick About in the Gravel

Write a few lines (3 to 7) to describe your experience in the following situation, remembering you have five senses: You are a sparrow. You are picking about among the gravel.

I had smelled no food amidst the scattered stones, but I dragged my beak through them anyway.

I felt them shift and scrape against each other before one nugget slipped between my jaws.

Moving my maxilla back and forth, I can feel it rock back and forth across my mandible.

I feel it slide down, almost audible like a greasy nail against a plastic-wrapped chalkboard.

I toss it into the air, catch it, and feel it slip too far and fill me up.